

1, Japan's Tang-Style Reforms Were Too Radical: The External Introduction of a bureaucratic system Prior to the classical period

Japan's early history lacks extensive historical records (what little exists is mostly found in Chinese historical sources). The most glaringly obvious characteristic discernible is its rapid progress. Particularly during the Yayoi period (弥生时代)—spanning roughly 300 BCE to 300 CE, a mere six centuries—the Japanese archipelago comprehensively achieved the popularization of rice-paddy agriculture, the introduction of bronze and iron implements, the emergence of a textile industry, the formation of an *early state* (早期国家) regime, and interactions with China.

It should be pointed out that Japan's rapid development during this period aligns with the general situation of peripheral regions during the zenith of **classical empires**; it was the result of the dramatic expansion of the Chinese Empire's influence during the five centuries from the Qin to the Western Jin dynasties. The progress of Japanese society could not have occurred without a massive influx of *Toraijin* (渡来人 / continental immigrants).

Starting from the end of the Western Jin, China entered a period of north-south division—the Eastern Jin, Sixteen Kingdoms, and Northern and Southern Dynasties periods—where ethnic minorities flooded into the Central Plains, and **feudalization** (封建化) deepened further.

Building upon the foundation of the previous era, Japan formed the Yamato state (大和王权 / Yamato Kingship). On the one hand, it still maintained diplomatic ties with the Southern Dynasties of China; on the other hand, it continued deep interactions with regimes on the Korean Peninsula. During this period, the Yamato state already possessed the capability to construct massive engineering projects like the *Kofun* (古坟 / megalithic tombs), established the *Uji-Kabane* system (氏姓制度 / clan and hereditary title system) to integrate powerful families into state politics, and encountered Buddhism, a world religion. These changes laid the foundation for the next stage of studying the Chinese Empire to implement reforms.

During the Asuka (飞鸟), Nara (奈良), and Heian (平安) periods, Japan dispatched nearly 20 delegations of envoys to the Sui and Tang empires. Their objective was to understand and learn the political systems and social culture of the Chinese Empire. The reason the Japanese court persisted in this policy for nearly three centuries may initially have been the desire to attain recognized international status (*which, in the political reality of East Asia, obviously meant being recognized by China*) and as a reaction to losing ground on the Korean Peninsula.

However, its fundamental cause lay in the fact that Japan had developed to the social stage of transitioning from an *early state* to a **classical state** (古典国家), possessing an internal drive to establish a classical *bureaucratic system* (官僚体制) and expand state power.

Yet, it is precisely here that the first problem arises. Japan certainly had a tendency to move toward a **classical state**, but whether it needed to do so *so early* and *so intensely* (i.e., having to rigidly model itself after China's *Ritsuryō* state / 律令国家) is clearly subject to immense doubt. I do not know whether Japanese scholars failed to notice this or intentionally avoided the issue (*after all, denying a phase of one's own country's historical development is certainly more difficult in public discourse than finding justifications for it*).

First, let us look at the initial issue: what were the respective domestic social conditions in the two countries on the eve of Japan's gradual adoption of the Tang Empire's systems?

In reality, even before becoming a *Ritsuryō* state, the systems Japan had groped its way toward (*undoubtedly also referencing regimes in the southern Korean Peninsula*) were not a blank slate. Systems such as the *Kuni no miyatsuko* (国造 / provincial administrators), *Miyake* (屯仓 / royal estates and granaries), the *Uji-Kabane* system (氏姓制度), and the *Be* system (部民制度 / occupational groups) had already taken shape.

Japan's "*Great King who rules all under heaven*" (*Ame-no-shita Shiroshimesu Ōkimi* / 治天下大王—that is, the later Emperor) completely possessed the ability to extract tribute and taxes from all over the kingdom and subject the commoners to corvée labor, while local magnates (地方豪族) were also absorbed into the kingdom's rule.

What I wish to point out is that although (*some—whenever I mention this, I mean a portion, as what I can read are just some classic works translated domestically*) Japanese scholars believe this royal power structure was extremely primitive, or even merely an exclusionary regional power bloc, it was not necessarily all that backward for the "classical" stage.

Japanese scholars argue that because a monistic (一元化) monarch-subject structure had not formed beneath the King of Wa (倭王), the Taika Reform (大化改新)—and subsequent reforms—were imperative.

However, a "monistic" structure was never an inevitable prerequisite for a classical empire to begin with. These scholars have clearly been strongly influenced by *Toyo Shigaku* (东洋史学 / Japanese academic study of East Asian, primarily Chinese, history), mistakenly adopting China's special case as a universally applicable standard. **An overly complete and aggressively powerful bureaucratic system emerged anomalously in China during its classical period; other classical empires inherently did not need to possess one.**

If we consider Japanese society on the eve of the promulgation and implementation of the *Taihō Code* (《大宝律令》) at the end of the 7th century CE, then aside from the Chinese Empire and the Roman Empire, the developmental level of Japan's classical bureaucratic system could no longer be said to be inferior to that of (early) Iran, (early) India, or the Khmer.

Therefore, assuming we exclude continental influence, it is highly doubtful whether the Japanese archipelago had any internal demand to develop an even more powerful political system. The fact is, once the potential military threats from the Tang Empire and Silla (新罗) distinctly vanished, the Heian court shed the high state of military readiness under the *Ritsuryō* system almost without any burden. For the next two centuries, the entire country remained at a low level of military activity, right up until the *Samurai* (武士) rose to power locally.

China, on the other hand, had developed into a bizarre stage that deviated from the normal historical trajectory. This is what foreign observers consider the rapid reconstruction of state capacity in the early Middle Ages, or what the West calls the "First Great Divergence" (第一次大分流). However, I clearly designate it as the ***Restoration-bureaucratic period*** (复辟官僚时期).

The system of the Sui and Tang empires during this period was by no means a simple repetition of the Qin and Han ***classical empires***, because the social foundation for its establishment had drastically changed. Regardless, by the 7th century CE, the ***feudal landlord class*** (封建地主阶级) already dominated economic production. The Tang emperors could no longer seek despotism through balancing acts like their Qin and Han counterparts; instead, they had to suppress the

landlord class through institutional design. In fact, throughout the Tang Dynasty, the policy toward the aristocratic great clans (士族) was indeed one of simultaneous utilization and precaution.

The core of this policy very likely inherited "**The Landlord-Bureaucrat Compromise**" (地主-官僚妥协), which had matured during the previous dynasties (the Sixteen Kingdoms and the Northern and Southern Dynasties) targeting the *barbarians* who had *Entered the Pass (Ru Guan)*. That is to say, it sought to weaken the local dominance of the aristocratic great clans, while providing them with compensation within the bureaucratic system (i.e., **co-optation through official ranks and stipends** / 官位荣禄).

More importantly, the *Ritsuryō* state was built upon a reactionary push against the tide of **feudalization** (封建化). Therefore, its policies appeared so radical as to be almost inconceivable. The most representative measure among them was the Equal-field system (均田制), where the **bureaucratic state** (官僚国家) attempted to directly control the distribution of the means of production.

The reason such radical measures could be adopted during Emperor Xiaowen's reign was, fundamentally, because years of perennial warfare in the North led to massive amounts of abandoned land. The two successive upheavals of the Revolt of the Six Garrisons (六镇起义) and the chaos at the end of the Sui Dynasty unexpectedly prolonged the lifespan during which the Equal-field system could survive.

However, once entering the Tang Dynasty, the situation relatively stabilized, and the bureaucratic government could no longer possibly have that much land to distribute. It had no way of manufacturing the basic unit of rule—the small-peasant household—through such a direct method.

From the very beginning, the Equal-field system did not involve the institutional confiscation of the massive landlords' land. The logic here is also exceedingly simple: if the court were to go so far as to seize the means of production from landowners for redistribution, then in the eyes of the landlords, how much would this behavior differ from **feudalization** itself? The court was absolutely unwilling to face fierce resistance.

Therefore, I must emphasize that while the Sui and Tang empires certainly achieved a bureaucratic restoration, their attempt did not mature all at once. Trying to use state power to directly distribute the means of production to establish a long-running foundational institution was simply a naive fantasy.

It was the Song Dynasty that truly pushed the **restoration-bureaucratic system** to maturity. Chinese rulers realized that the brilliance and essence of the **bureaucratic system** (官僚体制) lay in being detached from production (脱产). They found a path to maintain bureaucratic rule and continuously strengthen the monarch's dictatorial power merely by indirectly controlling the means of production. Over the total 289-year history of the Tang Dynasty, the time during which the *Ritsuryō* state could operate normally was actually less than half. This system was unworkable even in China.

Japan, meanwhile, faced social conditions completely different from those of the Tang Dynasty. Japanese scholars themselves admit that, let alone anything else, even the household registration system (户籍制度)—the cornerstone of the *Ritsuryō* state—was extremely difficult to implement in

Japan at the time. This was because, at the time of the *Ritsuryō* reforms, the Japanese archipelago did not even possess "families" (家庭) like those in the Tang Dynasty.

This was inevitable, because during the Tang Dynasty, the grassroots of society had indeed achieved **feudalization**, whereas the entirety of Japan was still full of clans and *Be* occupational groups (氏族部民). Therefore, I believe that under such massive social disparities between the two countries, claiming that Japan absolutely had to reform by mimicking the Tang Dynasty is entirely absurd.

Secondly, judging from the ultimate outcome of the *Ritsuryō* reforms, the question of exactly what Japan learned—and did not learn—from China becomes even more fascinating.

The imperial examination system (科举制), as a "fundamental grand law" perfected during the Tang Dynasty, was a powerful weapon for despotic monarchs of the restoration period to combat the aristocratic great clans. But in Japan, it proved utterly useless.

Because Japan had not even entered the classical period, clan aristocrats were still active on the political stage. Even from the perspective of the downward diffusion of knowledge, implementing the imperial examinations in Japan fundamentally lacked a suitable target audience; the only people who possessed the knowledge to participate were the aristocrats themselves. Therefore, shortly after this system was introduced to Japan, it existed in name only (名存实亡).

Similarly, the eunuch system (宦官制度) found no soil in Japan. The imperial family and the powerful clans (primarily the Fujiwara clan / 藤原氏) were practically in-laws for generations. The relationship between the two sides was overall stable, hence there was no need to strictly guard and defend the inner palace (后宫).

From the perspective of official titles, although the Japanese envoys to the Tang indeed arrived at the Tang Dynasty and attempted to replicate the Tang bureaucratic system, we can still discern obvious elements of the **Han System** (汉制) within it.

For example, the post of *Dainagon* (大纳言 / Major Counselor), which evolved from the Grandee Secretary (御史大夫) during Emperor Tenji's (天智天皇) reign, had a "Tang alias" (唐名) of "Secondary Chancellor" (亚相). As is widely known, the Grandee Secretary in the Han Dynasty was viewed as the alternate or understudy for the Chancellor.

An even more famous example is the title *Kampaku* (关白 / Regent). In China, this term was earliest used to refer to the political decision-making power of Huo Guang—the chief minister entrusted with the care of the young emperor upon Emperor Wu's death. Furthermore, the elegant alias for *Kampaku* in Japan, "Haku-roku" (博陆), originates directly from Huo Guang's own noble title, Marquis of Bolu (博陆侯).

Locally, the increasingly complex bureaucratic system of the Tang Dynasty was clearly neither what Japan needed nor what it could imitate. Transport, censorship, and state monopolies could not be executed in Japan back then. Local governance relied on the *Kokushi* (国司 / provincial governors). This situation, where local officials concentrated various powers in their hands, was much more akin to the Grand Administrators (太守) of the Han Dynasty than the Regional Inspectors (刺史) of the Tang.

In fact, the Japanese indeed referred elegantly to the *Kokushi* and even the later *Daimyo* as "Taishu" (太守)—though this likely violated the court's ritual protocols. Perhaps it was precisely because the *Kokushi* of various *Ritsuryō* provinces originally possessed relatively concentrated local power that the formation of *Zuryō* (受領 / contract governors) and *Fumyō* (負名 / named taxpayers) during the Heian period transitioned relatively smoothly under the harsh *Ritsuryō* system, thereby opening the path to the **feudal political system** (封建政治制度).

From the perspective of cultural history, the "time lag" (時差) between China and Japan is also extremely fascinating.

For example, the term "Shogunate" or "Bakufu" (幕府) in China referred to the administrative headquarters of top regional military commanders, and those serving within were aides or staff members (幕僚). In China, the *Bakufu* system took shape during the Qin and Han, and was most active during the climax of **feudalization**—the Wei, Jin, and Northern and Southern Dynasties. When this vocabulary spread to Japan, it later became the symbol of the feudal regime established by the *Samurai*.

Another artifact that left an extremely profound impression on me is a type of clothing, known in Chinese as *Liangdang* (两裆 / a two-piece tunic). There is a pottery figure from the Northern and Southern Dynasties period wearing this attire in the Shaanxi History Museum. This vest-like garment was equally prevalent during the Jin and Northern and Southern Dynasties, which was the zenith of **feudalization**. By the time the envoys to the Tang arrived in the Chinese Empire, it had already lost its former glory, and by the Song Dynasty, it had vanished completely.

In Japan, however, the shape of the *Liangdang* was resurrected in the *Kariginu* (狩衣 / hunting robe) that emerged during the Heian period, although there is no evidence of a direct lineage between the two. When viewed from the front, a high-ranking Japanese *Samurai* or *Kuge* (公卿 / court noble) wearing a *Kariginu* looks as if they are wearing a *Liangdang* over their clothes.

I previously downloaded the complete series of *Taiheiki* (《太平記》) from Baidu Tieba and watched it several times; in the show, Ashikaga Takauji (足利尊氏), played by Hiroyuki Sanada, frequently appears in this attire after becoming the Shogun. The reason this shape was preserved was ultimately because it suited the needs of the feudalized aristocracy for martial exercises and hunting. Additionally, armor modeled after the *Liangdang* shape was also highly popular in *Buke* (武家 / warrior family) society.

During the Northern and Southern Dynasties in China, aristocratic women who took Buddhist vows and became nuns were often respectfully addressed as "Nun So-and-so" (某某尼). Japan retained this custom, and it was also most common in warrior society. As late as the Sengoku period, the mother of Imagawa Yoshimoto (今川義元) was still known as Jukei-ni (寿桂尼).

It is precisely this "time lag" exhibited in Japan's protracted interactions with China that clearly and explicitly reflects the temporal disparity in the historical trajectories of the two countries.

Finally, I believe there is one more piece of evidence indicating that Japan's adoption of Tang Dynasty systems for reform during the Asuka and Nara periods was unnecessary: namely, the typical, genuine classical Japan exhibited a certain "delay" (滞后).

What does this mean? The **classical empire** I refer to here is a centralized state formed during the transition from a clan-based aristocratic society to a **feudal society**. Consequently, the bureaucrats and intellectuals of a **classical empire** often possess complex origins in their identities, which itself is an important manifestation of "class balancing" (阶级平衡).

However, during the reforms of the 7th and 8th centuries CE, such a situation did not yet exist in Japanese society. In reality, when the Chinese **bureaucratic system** was transplanted, the absolute majority constituting the bureaucrats were the original clan aristocrats. This in itself was highly bizarre.

For example, the extraordinarily renowned aristocratic Fujiwara clan (藤原氏) in Japan was originally called the Nakatomi clan (中臣氏), which belonged to the **priestly class** (祭司阶级) in charge of religious ceremonies. According to the general course of historical development, accompanying the advancement of production, the diffusion of knowledge, and the very changes in religious beliefs themselves, when a society enters the classical period, this stratum, even if not entirely stripped of power, should at least severely decline.

Yet, the Nakatomi clan capitalized on the nationwide trend of Tang-style reforms in Japan, defeated their enemies in political struggles, and integrated themselves into the bureaucratic system, eventually becoming the absolute zenith of the *Kuge* (公卿 / court nobles). This in itself is quite legendary.

The key reason why such seemingly bizarre events could occur is that Japan's "classical system" appeared far too early. It was not that they were naturally entering the classical period by the 7th and 8th centuries; rather, under external influence, they prematurely transplanted the bureaucratic system. Meanwhile, back then, the **old nobility** like the Nakatomi clan were still highly active on the political stage, thereby managing to occupy vital positions within the bureaucratic system.

If we cast our gaze further down the timeline, the evidence becomes even more glaring. During the final nearly one hundred years of the Heian period, the *Insei* (院政 / Cloistered Rule) system emerged, directly terminating the nearly century-long Regency politics (*Sekkan Seiji* / 摄关政治) of the Fujiwara clan.

Under the *Insei* system, the retired emperor held power in the capacity of a *Jōkō* (上皇 / Cloistered Emperor) or *Hōō* (法皇 / Cloistered Emperor who has taken Buddhist vows), while the *Kuge* and hundreds of officials waited with fear and trepidation for him to issue *Insen* (院宣 / edicts from the cloistered emperor).

Japanese scholars have clearly noticed two points.

First, when the *Jōkō* implemented *Insei*, he would promote a group of close attendants (*Kinshin* / 近臣). The identity origins of these close attendants were extremely complex, and their personnel appointments frequently breached the general conventions of the aristocratic state (*i.e., the default rules of the early to mid-Heian period*). Relying on the *Jōkō*'s trust, these close attendants attained astonishing power and wealth, provoking much criticism among the *Kuge*, who could only sigh in helpless resignation.

Second, the emergence of *Insei* occurred later than the *Samurai* (武士) stepping onto the historical stage. In fact, Japanese scholars can very easily point out that the *Samurai* themselves were part of

the *Jōkō*'s political balancing game. For instance, the *Hokumen no Bushi* (北面武士 / Northern-facing Warriors) was the military force supporting the *Insei* of Cloistered Emperor Shirakawa (白河法皇).

Even during the 30 years prior to the Genpei War (源平合戦), this political balance itself already had to be struck between the Minamoto (源) and Taira (平) *Samurai* clans. The Taira clan regime—peaking with the despotism of Taira no Kiyomori (平清盛)—became the "*Tōryō of the Buke*" (武家栋梁 / Head of the Warrior Houses) precisely under the sponsorship of the *Jōkō* for the purpose of suppressing the Minamoto clan (*the quotation marks indicate that the title did not match the reality*).

However, because the *Samurai* had already acquired an absolutely dominant position in the nation's military by the 12th century, and their self-awareness was gradually germinating, the *Jōkō*'s balancing act failed very quickly. Thus, when Minamoto no Yoritomo (源頼朝) seized state power, Japan immediately entered the *Chūsei* (中世 / Middle Ages or medieval society).

These two points actually fully demonstrate that the *Insei* of the late Heian period was the typical classical politics. On the one hand, its bureaucratic origins necessarily possessed breadth and complexity, while the selection of close attendants relied on the ruler's personal will. On the other hand, class substitution can only occur after the landlord class steps onto the historical stage. This is exactly why *Insei* could only emerge after the *Samurai* had gained vital positions in state politics.

If we look at this from the perspective of economic circulation, this point is similarly corroborated. Although there were considerable official interactions between Japan and the Tang Dynasty in the 7th and 8th centuries CE, Japan's external international trade was not highly developed.

It was not until the late Heian period, particularly its final stage when Taira no Kiyomori (平清盛) held power, that Japan's foreign trade exhibited the prosperity typical of the classical period. Not only was the trade volume massive, but the commodities also became more diversified (for instance, Japanese handicraft products like folding fans entered China). The massive influx of Song Dynasty copper coins into Japan illustrates the development of Japan's commodity economy.

This phenomenon becomes quite reasonable if we explain it by suggesting that when Japan transplanted the Chinese bureaucratic system, it still needed time to reach the classical society; it initially lacked the social conditions for prosperous commercial activities, which were only gradually realized by the late Heian period.

If we follow the current general understanding and view the Nara and Heian periods as classical Japan, then the typical classical period merely accounted for little more than its final one-fifth of the time. In fact, although the establishment of the Kamakura Shogunate allowed the *Samurai* to mature politically, it did not alter the status quo of Japanese society operating under the *Shōen-Kōryō* system (庄园公领制 / estate and public land system) since the late Heian period. This resulted in the classical era leaving a tiny "tail" more than a century after the end of the Heian period—namely, the Kenmu Restoration (建武新政) advocated by Emperor Go-Daigo (后醍醐天皇).

Japanese scholars have likewise noted that although Go-Daigo himself used "*Unification under the Court Nobles*" (公家一统) as his slogan, the personnel supporting his regime similarly had complex origins and were promoted based on their intimate relationships with the emperor himself. (*The*

Kodansha book references Amino Yoshihiko's / 网野善彦 concept of the "Heteromorphic Kingship" / 异形的王权).

Go-Daigo himself did not respect the general rules of *Kuge* (court noble) society, to the point that Kitabatake Chikafusa (北畠亲房)—serving as the main pillar of the Southern Court—expressed deep regret in his *Jinnō Shōtōki* (《神皇正统记》 / *Chronicle of the Direct Descent of Gods and Sovereigns*) when discussing the emperor's "reckless decrees" (乱命).

One of the most astonishing examples occurred in December 1334, when Emperor Go-Daigo appointed *Kuge*, including incumbent ministers, as the lords of the Eight Ministries (八省卿). This practically negated the bureaucratic political logic inherited from the Tang Dynasty—that is, the various practical administrative departments are first responsible to the chancellor, and then the chancellor is responsible to the emperor.

Emperor Go-Daigo had absolutely no need for the Council of State (议政官会议) to assist or obstruct him. He turned the ministers and all officials below them entirely into practical administrative officials, making them execution organs to realize the emperor's will. Emperor Go-Daigo wished that both the *Zasso Ketsudansho* (杂诉决断所 / Board of Miscellaneous Lawsuits) serving as his think tank and the political institutions serving as execution organs would belong exclusively to himself. This line of thought bears an uncanny resemblance to Zhu Yuanzhang (朱元璋) half a century later.

The aforementioned facts indicate that Emperor Go-Daigo's Kenmu regime was essentially still a regime based on classical logic. However, let alone lasting for a generation, he could not even sustain it for three years. This is because although the shadow of the *Ritsuryō* system remained, the *Samurai* had already indisputably risen as the new masters of the state; the emperor had no room left whatsoever to manipulate class balances.

Since the tail of classical Japan survived until such a late date, it is evident that in the distant era of the 7th and 8th centuries, the Japanese archipelago was still far from the stage of spontaneously forming a **classical state**. (However, I later discovered that Japan's situation was far from outrageous. During Iran's classical phase spanning more than 11 centuries in the pre-Islamic period, the typical classical society only existed in the final 150 years).

In other words, when Japan's history reached the 7th and 8th centuries CE, without being prepared to enter the **classical state**, Japan forcibly introduced the *Ritsuryō* system—a new system generated during China's stage of bureaucratic restoration. This is akin to a healthy person taking an excessively potent medicine (later I discovered that the "medicine" of the *Ritsuryō* system was, in reality, essentially a poison).

Why did the rulers of Japan do this? On this specific issue, my personal opinion is no different from the Japanese scholars I have read: namely, that in the 7th and 8th centuries CE, Japan indeed felt a severe military threat from the East Asian mainland.

I merely point out, **building upon the foundation of Japanese scholars**, that this severe military threat ostensibly originated from the extremely high intensity of warfare throughout the Tang Dynasty, but fundamentally, it was the product of the **bureaucratic restoration**.

Because if **feudalization** had continued after the migrations of ethnic minorities, the organizational capacity of early medieval society would have still been very weak. The scope of personnel and

material circulation might have receded compared to the classical period, and the intensity of warfare would have been maintained at a rather low level.

Yet in China, none of this occurred. The **bureaucratic state** was resurrected through such forceful means as the laws and regulations of the *Ritsuryō* system (*Lü Ling Ge Shi* / 律令格式). The Tang Empire was able to invest hundreds of thousands of men into border expansion wars. In particular, the Tang Empire's intervention wars on the Korean Peninsula not only completely crushed the Japanese army in pitched battles but also, alongside Silla, exerted colossal pressure on Japan.

In fact, the impact of the Tang Dynasty's foreign wars clearly rippled beyond Japan. If we accept the "time lag hypothesis" (时差假设) that China, as the center of East Asian civilization, originally led the various peripheral sub-centers in the stages of social development, then when the Sui and Tang empires rose, regimes in a predicament similar to Japan's were clearly not limited to just one.

In fact, when we observe two of the Tang Empire's most significant frontier adversaries—the Tubo (Tibetan Empire) and Nanzhao—it is not difficult to discover exactly how the Tang Empire's military pressure affected China's frontiers.

In the Yunnan region, *slavery states* already existed as early as the Qin and Han periods. After several centuries of development since the Wei, Jin, and Northern and Southern Dynasties, the local society was undoubtedly striding toward a classical society. The rise of the Tang Dynasty massively accelerated this process. In reality, we know today that Nanzhao similarly modeled its politics, economy, and military after the Tang system, thereby mobilizing massive armed forces to confront the Tang Empire.

As for the Tibetan Plateau, due to its late start and harsh environment, the society there was even more backward. When the Sui and Tang empires rose, it was, at best, in the stage of a general (slavery-based) *early state*. However, driven by the pressure and advanced technologies from the Tang Dynasty, Tubo also rapidly hyper-inflated into a centralized slavery empire, becoming the Tang Dynasty's most powerful foreign enemy during its middle period.

For the neighbors of the Tang Empire, the military, political, economic, and cultural influence of the Tang Dynasty caused them to prematurely inflate into classical-form empires. Consequently, the social mutation that occurred in the Chinese interior during the late Northern and Southern Dynasties (*where it did not continue along the path of **feudalization**, but veered toward a bureaucratic restoration*) spread to China's periphery alongside the influence of the Tang Dynasty.

For example, when we observe the demise of the Tubo Empire, we note a highly unique event: a nationwide great slave uprising. This illustrates at least three points: **First**, the Tubo Empire was a prematurely hyper-inflated classical-form empire, where slavery remained the primary mode of exploitation. **Second**, a slave uprising that destroys an empire across such a vast ruling expanse is exceedingly rare in the world, indicating that the Tubo Empire had excessively extracted social resources during its protracted foreign wars. **Third**, while rebellions certainly occur in the late stages of *classical empires*, it is very difficult for the empire itself to be directly destroyed by them. The reason is that the already feudalized landlord class will use the momentum of suppressing the rebellion to augment their own power, exactly as occurred during the Yellow Turban Rebellion at the end of the Eastern Han Dynasty. Tubo, however, possessed absolutely no capability to contain the prairie fire of the uprising. This demonstrates that its society was still very far from **feudalization**; there simply were no **feudal lords** (封建领主) who could step forward to handle the

situation, to the extent that after the Tubo central government collapsed, the entire territory descended into stateless anarchy.

Based precisely on this observation, we can say that although Japan's choice to conduct comprehensive reforms modeled after the Tang Dynasty during the Asuka and Nara periods was bizarre from the perspective of Japan's own developmental trajectory, considering the historical reality emerging in the East Asian region at the time, one must admit that this choice possessed a certain inevitability.

What happened next can be called a genuine heroic saga in human history.

Regardless of the extent to which Japan failed to completely replicate the centralized system of the Tang Dynasty, after passing through the Nara period, Japan's bureaucratic rule—due to studying China—remained significantly stronger than that of typical *classical states*.

When reading relevant materials, I was profoundly astonished by some of the ideologies and reflections generated in Japanese society at that time, because even today, I can still sense their existence in China.

For instance, during the early Heian period, the Japanese court's attitude toward its borders was virtually identical to that of the Chinese Empire: if *barbarians* crossed the border and migrated into the empire, they must have been moved by the virtue of the Son of Heaven. The court never spared the wealth and labor of the people (民脂民膏) to grant them favorable treatment. However, if the empire's own commoners attempted to cross the border and head to "filthy" uncivilized lands, it was deemed treason; if caught, they were severely punished without leniency.

In reality, back then, there were indeed many commoners—registered households under the *Ritsuryō* system—who fled to areas controlled by the Emishi (虾夷) because they could no longer endure the court's cruel oppression. How remarkably similar this is to the Han-ethnicity commoners on China's northern frontier fleeing beyond the Great Wall!

Yamanoue no Okura (山上忆良), a Japanese poet of the Asuka and Nara periods, can be called the conscience of intellectuals. He himself suffered no great calamities as an official; although not fast, he promoted steadily within the bureaucratic system and maintained a very deep personal friendship with Ōtomo no Tabito (大伴旅人), the Dazaifu Commander (太宰帅 / a high regional official). Yet, Okura did not become a defender of the existing system. His poetry consistently stood on the side of the masses, unreservedly depicting the suffering of the people under the *Ritsuryō* system.

Not only did he live earlier than China's Du Fu (杜甫), but he was also far more ideologically progressive. Okura never shied away from the fact that the people's suffering originated from the court itself, whereas Du Fu always veiled his critiques (遮遮掩掩).

It was precisely under such a harsh social environment—and without having experienced the historical event of the Great Migrations to provide an external motive for *feudalization*—that the Japanese *Samurai* terminated bureaucratic rule purely from within. This transformed Japan, during the centuries following the mid-Heian period, into a *feudal society* similar to that of Western Europe. The sheer caliber of this magnificent achievement goes without saying.

Japan's history reminds me of an interesting story I once read, which took place on Pohnpei, the island where the capital of the present-day Federated States of Micronesia is located. This island likely sat along the path of Austronesian expansion into the Pacific.

A story circulates on Pohnpei that before the 12th century, the earliest settlers had already landed on the island, though they were still in a tribal society at the time. Around the year 1100, a group of conquerors distinctly different from the locals arrived on the island via canoes. They brought something the islanders had never seen before—namely, a government—and established the Saudeleur Dynasty.

This new regime constructed magnificent megalithic structures, using what is now the World Heritage site of Nan Madol as its capital. Naturally, this inevitably brought oppression. The regime forced the people to offer massive amounts of food to the spirits as tribute, making local class differentiation increasingly pronounced.

The ruled populace began continuous attempts at resistance, such as assassinating the king and stealing tributes. Sometime in the 17th century, the rule of the Saudeleur Dynasty finally became completely unsustainable. It is said that a hero conquered this kingdom; centralized state rule was abolished, and several large tribes co-ruled the island.

Pohnpei is extremely small, and the history that occurred there is quite simple to recount. However, it clearly illustrates what happens when an overly advanced social system is forcibly introduced into a region incapable of supporting it.

The overall direction of Austronesian migration was from west to east. When later migrants set sail from the coast of the Asian continent, they were likely already accustomed to the morphology of an **early state** (早期国家). They found it difficult to realize that when sailing eastward to Pacific islands, restricted by the island's size and accompanied by a loss of technology, maintaining their original social form in the new territory was simply unfeasible.

Fundamentally speaking, although Japan is vastly larger than Pohnpei, its historical encounter was exactly the same.

*Furthermore, the **restoration-bureaucratic system** (复辟官僚制度) of the Sui and Tang empires had absolutely nothing to do with being "advanced"; it was entirely a tumor (肿瘤) grown on the "organism" (机体) of human society. Japanese society lacked the conditions to allow this tumor to grow unchecked, and the Japanese Samurai subsequently waged a resolute struggle against it. Consequently, the Japanese archipelago ultimately returned to the normal trajectory of historical development.*

1, 日本的仿唐改革太过激进, 明显早于古典时期从外部引入了官僚制度

日本的早期历史并没有太多的历史记录(有也是在中国史料中), 能看出最为明显的特征就是其进步的迅速, 特别是在公元前后 300 年间的弥生时代仅仅不到六个世纪的时间里, 日本列岛就从整体上完成了水稻农业普及, 青铜器和铁器传入, 出现纺织业, 出现原始国家政权并且与中国交往。应当指出, 日本在这一时期的飞速发展符合古典帝国盛期周边地区的一般情况, 正是秦至西晋五个世纪中华帝国影响力急剧扩大的结果。日本社会的进步离不开大量的渡来人。从西晋末年中国进入了南北分裂, 少数民族涌入中原的东晋十六国南北朝时期, 封建化进一步加深。日本则在前一个时代的基础上形成了大和王权国家, 一方面仍与南朝保持着外交往来, 另一方面继续与今天韩国地区的政权交往颇深。这一时期大和国家已经有能力建设像古坟这样的大型工程, 并且形成了一种“氏姓”制度将一些强大的家族纳入到国家政治中, 又接触到了佛教这一世界宗教, 这些变化都为下一个阶段学习中华帝国进行改革奠定了基础。在飞鸟, 奈良, 平安时期, 日本向隋唐帝国派遣了前后近 20 批使臣, 其目的在于了解并学习中华帝国的政治体制和社会文化。日本朝廷之所以会在将近三个世纪里坚持这一政策, 从最初来看可能是希望获得被承认的(显然在东亚的政治现实中, 主要就被中国承认)国际地位以及对于在朝鲜半岛失势的一种反应, 但其根本原因在于日本发展到了由早期国家转型为古典国家的社会阶段, 存在一种建立

古典官僚体制，扩张国家权力的动力。然而就是在这里产生了第一个问题，日本列岛固然有走向古典国家的趋势，但是究竟是否那么早、那么强（也就是非得仿照中国的律令国家）显然存在巨大疑问，不知道日本学者是没有注意到，还是有意回避了这个问题（毕竟否认本国历史的一段发展历程肯定在舆论上要难于为其寻找合理性）。

首先来看第一个问题，那就是在日本逐渐向唐帝国制度学习的前夜，两国国内分别处于什么样的社会状况。实际上即使在成为律令国家之前，日本自己摸索出的制度（当然也肯定参考了朝鲜半岛南部的政权）本身已经不是一片空白，国造、屯仓和氏姓、部民制度已经形成，日本的“治天下大王”（也就是后来的天皇）完全有从王国各地取得贡品税收，使百姓服役的能力，地方豪族也被吸纳到王国的统治中。我想指出的是，虽然（一些，以后说到这种都是指部分，毕竟我能看到的也就是国内翻译的一些经典作品）日本学者认为这种王权结构十分原始，甚至还是具有排他性的地域权力集团，但其在“古典”这一阶段未必见得有多落后。日本学者认为倭王之下没有形成一元化的君臣结构，所以大化改新（以及其余改革）势在必行，然而“一元化”本来就不是古典帝国的必然要求，这些学者很明显受到了东洋史学的强烈影响，把中国的特殊情况当成了放之四海而皆准的标准。中国在古典时期反常的出现了一套过于完备和强势的官僚体制，而其他古典帝国本就不需要有。

如果考虑公元七世纪末《大宝律令》颁布并实施前夜的日本社会，那么除了中华帝国和罗马帝国以外，日本的古典官僚制发展的程度已经不能说比（早期）伊朗、（早期）印度或高棉要差了。因此假设排除来自大陆的影响，日本列岛自身还有没有需求发展出一套更加有力的政治体制是很值得怀疑的。事实就是当唐帝国和新罗潜在的军事威胁明显消失之后，平安朝廷几乎没有任何负担地放弃了律令制下的高度战备状态，接下来两个世纪整个国家处于一种低军事活动水平，直到武士在地方上崛起为止。另一方面的中国已经发展到了一个奇异的、偏离正常路径的阶段，也就是外国观察者所认为的在中古早期迅速重建了国家能力与西方所谓的“第一次大分流”，但是我很清楚地将其命名为官僚复辟时期或复辟官僚时期。这个时期隋唐帝国的体制绝不是仅仅简单地重复了秦汉的古典帝国，因为其成立的社会基础已经大为不同了，无论如何到公元七世纪的时候封建地主阶级已经主导了经济生产，唐朝的皇帝不可能再像秦汉的同行一样在平衡中寻求专制，而是必须从制度设计上对于地主阶级进行压制，事实上有唐一代对于士族确实采取了既用又防的政策。而这种政策的核心很可能继承了前朝（十六国南北朝）已经成熟的针对入关蛮族的“地主-官僚妥协”，也就是追求削弱士族在地方的主导权，而予以官僚制内的补偿（官位荣禄）。更为重要的是，律令国家建立在对于封建化浪潮的反动上，所以其政策看起来极为激进以至于到了不可思议的地步，其中最具有代表性的措施即均田制，官僚国家试图直接控制生产资料的分配。在孝文帝统治的年代之所以能够采取这样激进的措施，归根到底是北方常年战乱导致土地抛荒极多，六镇起义和隋末战乱两次相继的变故意外增加了均田制可能存续的时间。

然而一旦进入唐代，局势相对稳定下来，官僚政府就不可能再有那么多地来分了，他没办法通过如此直接的方式去制造统治的基本单位，也就是小农家庭。均田制一开始就不涉及从制度上没收大地主的土地，这个逻辑也极为简单，如果朝廷甚至要从土地所有者那里夺取生产资料进行再分配的话，那这种行为在地主们看来本身跟封建化又能差多少，朝廷是绝不愿意面临激烈的反抗的。所以我必须强调，隋唐帝国固然实现了官僚复辟，但是其尝试不是一下子就成熟的，试图用国家力量直接分配生产资料来建立一个长久运行的基本制度就是一种幼稚的幻想。真正将官僚复辟体制推向成熟的是宋朝，中国统治者意识到了官僚体制的妙处和精华就在于脱产，并且找到了一条通过间接控制生产资料就可以维护官僚统治并不断加强君主独裁权力的道路。唐代总共 289 年的历史，律令制国家能够照常运行的时间根本不到一半，这套体制就是在中国也行不通。而日本面临的社会情况完全不同于唐朝，日本学者自己也承认就算不说别的，就是作为律令国家基石的户籍制度在当年的日本也很难推行，因为日本列岛在律令改革的时候甚至还不存在唐代那样的“家庭”。这是必然的，因为唐代在社会基层确实实现了封建化，而日本全国还到处都是氏族部民。所以我认为，在两国社会差异如此巨大的情况下，说日本必须要仿照唐朝进行改革是完全荒谬的。

其次，从律令改革后的最终结果来看，日本从中国究竟学了什么又没有学什么，这个问题就更有意思了。科举制作为在唐代完善的一项“根本大法”，是复辟时期的专制君主为了对抗士族的一个有力武器，但是在日本就毫无作用。因为日本甚至连古典时期还都没有进入，氏族贵族还活跃在政治舞台上，即使从知识下沉的角度来说，在日本实施科举根本就没有适合的面向对象，能有知识参与的人本身也就是贵族们，因此这个制度在引入日本之后很快名存实亡。与之相似，宦官制度也在日本不存在土壤，天皇家

族和有力氏族（主要是藤原氏）几乎世代为姻亲，双方的关系整体稳定，因而也就没有对后宫严防死守的需求。从官职上看，虽然日本遣唐使到达的确是唐朝，试图复制的也是唐朝的官制，但是我们还是能从中看到明显的汉制。例如由天智天皇时期御史大夫演变而来的大纳言一职，这个官职的“唐名”是“亚相”，而众所周知汉代御史大夫被视为丞相的替补。更为有名的例子是“关白”，这个词在中国最早就用来指汉武帝去世时的首席托孤大臣霍光在政治决策中的权势，而关白在日本的雅名“博陆”来源于霍光本人的爵位博陆侯。而在地方上，唐代已经日益复杂的官僚体制显然既不是日本需要的也不是日本能够模仿的，转运、监察、专卖在当年的日本无法被执行，地方统治仰赖国司，这种地方官员集中掌握各类权力的情况更类似于汉代的太守而不是唐代的刺史，实际上日本人确实也将国守甚至大名称为“太守”（大概不符合朝廷礼法的）。或许正是各个令制国国司拥有原本就相对集中的地方权力，平安时期受领和负名的形成才在严苛的律令制下转变得相对顺畅，进而打开了通向封建制度的道路。

从文化史的角度来看中日两国之间的时差也很有意思，例如“幕府”这个词在中国指的是封疆大吏的府属，在其中供职的人即是幕僚。在中国，幕府形成于秦汉，而在封建化的高潮时期也就是魏晋南北朝年间最为活跃。这一词汇传到日本，日后成为了武士所建立的封建政权的象征。另一个给我印象极为深刻的物件是一种服饰，汉语里叫作“两裆”，陕西历史博物馆里面有一个穿着这种服饰的南北朝时期陶俑。这种背心式服装同样盛行于两晋南北朝这一封建化鼎盛的时期，等到遣唐使们到达中华帝国的时候，它已经风光不再，到宋代则彻底消失。而在日本，两裆的形状又复活在了平安时代出现的狩衣当中，尽管没有证据表明两者之间有直接的传承关系。穿着狩衣的日本高级武士或者公卿从正面看仿佛是在衣服外面套了一件两裆。我之前从百度贴吧里面下了《太平记》全集也看了好几遍，剧中真田广之饰演的足利尊氏在成为幕府将军之后就经常着这种服饰现身。之所以这种形状被保留下来，归根到底是其适应了封建化贵族演武狩猎的需求，另外两裆形制的甲冑在武家社会也非常流行。在南北朝时期，信佛出身的贵族女性往往被尊为“某某尼”，日本保留了这种习惯并且也是在武家社会最为常见，一直到战国时代，今川义元的母亲还被称为寿桂尼。正是日本在和中国长期交流中所表现的这种“时差”清晰明了地反映了两国历史进程在时间上的差异性。

最后，我认为飞鸟奈良时期日本依照唐朝制度进行改革是非必要的还有一个证据就是典型意义的古典日本存在一定的“滞后”。这是什么意思呢？我这里所谓的古典帝国是指由氏族贵族社会向封建社会过渡中形成的中央集权国家，因而古典帝国的官僚和知识分子往往在身份上具有复杂的来源，这本身也是“阶级平衡”的一个重要体现。但是在公元七八世纪的改革中，日本社会还不存在这种情况，实际上当中国的官僚制度被移植之后，构成官僚绝对主体的都是原先的氏族贵族，这本身就是很奇怪的。例如日本大名鼎鼎的贵族家族藤原氏，其原本被称为中臣氏，属于掌管宗教仪式的祭司。按照一般的历史进程来说，伴随着生产发展，知识的扩散以及宗教信仰本身的变化，当一个社会进入古典时期，这个阶层即使不说完全失势，至少也是严重衰落的。但是中臣氏却利用了日本全国仿唐改革的形势，在政治斗争中击败了敌人，从而将自己融入了官僚系统，以至于日后成为公卿的顶点，这本来就颇为传奇。而之所以能有这样看似奇怪的事情发生，关键在于日本的“古典体制”出现得太早，不是到公元七八世纪就已经要进入古典时期，而是在外界的作用下过早地移植了官僚制度，而在当年如中臣氏这样的旧贵族依然活跃在政治舞台上，从而得以在官僚体制内占有重要地位。

如果我们把目光往回看，证据变得更加明显。在平安时代的最后近一个世纪里出现了“院政”，直接结束了藤原氏近一个世纪的摄关政治。在院政体制下，退位的天皇以上皇或者法皇的身份掌控权力，公卿百官则战战兢兢地等待他下达“院宣”。日本的学者明显注意到了两点，第一点是上皇在实施院政的时候会提拔一批近臣，这些近臣身份来源十分复杂，而人事任免则时常突破贵族国家的一般惯例（也就是平安中前期的默认规则）。这些近臣倚仗上皇的信任得到了惊人的权势和财富，使公卿之间多有非议，但是又徒叹奈何。第二点则是院政的出现晚于武士登上历史舞台，实际上日本学者也可以非常轻易地指出，武士本身就是上皇的政治平衡游戏的一部分，例如北面武士就是支持白河法皇院政的军事力量。甚至于在源平合战的前30年里，这种政治平衡本身就已经必须在源平武士之间达成了，以平清盛专制为顶峰的平氏政权本身就是在上皇的扶植下以打压源氏为目的而成为“武家栋梁”（这个引号意指其名不副实）的。但是由于武士在公元12世纪时已经在国家军事中占据了绝对优势的地位，且其自我意识逐渐萌生，上皇的平衡术很快便失败了，于是当源赖朝取得政权之时，日本便进入了中世社会。这两点其实充分表明，平安晚期的院政才是典型的古典政治，一方面其官僚来源必然具有广泛性和复杂性，而近臣

的选用则依赖统治者的个人意志，另一方面地主阶级只有登上历史舞台才可能发生阶级更替，这也是为什么当武士能够在国家政治中取得重要地位之后院政才会出现。

如我们从经济流通的角度来看这一点同样得到了印证，虽然在公元七、八世纪日本与唐朝的官方往来不少，但是日本对外的国际贸易并不发达。直到平安时代后期特别是最后阶段，也就是平清盛掌权的时候，日本对外贸易才呈现出了古典时期的繁荣景象，不仅仅是贸易量很大，商品也更加多元化（比如日本的手工业制品折扇就进入了中国），宋朝铜钱大量流入日本说明了日本商品经济的发展。这种现象如果用日本在移植中国官僚制度的时候距离古典社会尚需时日，最初缺少繁荣商业活动的社会条件，直到平安后期才逐渐实现来解释就合理了。如果按照现在一般的认识把奈良平安时期视为古典日本的话，那么典型的古典时期仅仅在其最后 1/5 多的时间。而事实上，镰仓幕府的建立虽然使武士在政治上走向成熟，但是并没有改变平安后期以来日本社会依庄园公领制运行的现状，这就导致古典时代在平安时期结束一个多世纪之后留下了小小的一个尾巴，也就是后醍醐天皇所倡导的建武新政。

日本学者同样注意到后醍醐本人虽然以“公家一统”为口号但支撑其政权的进程同样来源复杂，依据与天皇本人的亲密关系而被提拔（讲谈社的书中提到了网野善彦所说的“异形的王权”）。后醍醐本人并不尊重公家社会的一般规则，以至于北畠亲房作为南朝一方的中流砥柱在写《神皇正统记》时谈到天皇的“乱命”也表示十分遗憾。一个最为惊人的例子是在 1334 年 12 月，后醍醐天皇将现任大臣在内的公卿任命为八省卿，这在实际上否认了从唐朝沿袭的官僚政治逻辑，也就是各实务部门先对宰相负责，而后宰相对皇帝负责。后醍醐天皇完全不需要议政官会议来辅佐或者阻碍自己，他让大臣及其以下官吏全部变成实务官员，令其成为实现天皇意志的执行机关。后醍醐天皇希望作为智库的杂诉决断所和作为执行机关的政治机构都只属于自己，这一思路跟半个世纪之后的朱元璋极为神似。以上事实表明，后醍醐天皇的建武政权，本质上还是一个基于古典逻辑的政权，但是他不要说一代人，连三年都已经坚持不了了，这是因为虽然律令制的影子还在，但是武士已经毫无悬念地作为国家的新主人崛起了，天皇没有任何操弄阶级平衡的余地。既然古典日本的尾巴存留到了如此之晚的时候，可见在七八世纪的遥远年代日本列岛还远没到自发形成古典国家的阶段。（不过后面我才发现，日本的情况远非离谱，伊朗在前伊斯兰时期长达 11 个世纪还多的古典阶段中，典型的古典社会只存在于最后 150 年）

也就是说，当日本的历史走到公元第七、八世纪，在没有做好进入古典国家的准备的情况下，日本强行引入了律令制这一中国在官僚复辟阶段所产生的新体制，这就好比一个没什么病的人吃了一种药效过强的药（后来我发现律令制这种药实在就是一种毒药）。为什么日本的统治者要这么做？在这个具体问题上，我本人的意见跟我看到的日本学者没有差别，那就是日本在公元七八世纪确实感受到了来自东亚大陆的强烈军事威胁。而我则在日本学者的基础上指出，这种强烈军事威胁从表面上看来源于有唐一代极高的战争烈度，从根本来讲则是官僚复辟的产物。因为如果封建化在少数民族迁徙之后被继续下去，那么中世纪早期社会的组织能力还是很弱的，人员和物资流通的范围比起古典时期都可能衰退，战争烈度会保持一个相当低的水平。而在中国这一切都没有发生，官僚国家通过律令格式这样强势的手段复活了，唐帝国得以投入几十万人进行拓边战争，特别是唐帝国对于朝鲜半岛的干涉战争不但在会战中完全打垮了日军，而且与新罗一道对日本形成了巨大的压力。实际上，唐朝对外战争的影响显然不止波及了日本，如果我们接受中国作为东亚文明中心在社会发展阶段上原本领先周边各个副中心这一“时差假设”，那么当隋唐帝国崛起的时候，与日本处于相似处境的政权显然不止一个。

实际当我们观察唐帝国的两个重要对手：吐蕃和南诏，就不难发现，唐帝国的军事压力是以何种形式影响到了中国的边疆。云南地区早在秦汉时期已经存在奴隶制国家，经过魏晋南北朝以来数个世纪的发展，当地社会无疑正在向古典社会迈进。而唐朝的崛起大大加速了这一过程，事实上我们今天知道南诏在政治经济和军事上同样仿照唐代体制，由此动员出庞大的武装力量同唐帝对抗。而对于青藏高原而言，这里的社会因为起步晚和环境恶劣要更加落后，隋唐帝国崛起时，这里充其量处于一般（奴隶制）早期国家时期。但是由于来自唐代的压力和先进技术，吐蕃也迅速膨胀成为一个中央集权的奴隶制帝国，唐代中期最为强大的外敌。对于唐帝国的邻居们而言，唐朝的军事、政治、经济和文化影响，使得他们过早地膨胀成为一个古典形态的帝国。这样一来，从中国南北朝晚期中国内地发生的社会异变

（没有沿着封建化道路继续行进，而是转向官僚复辟）随着唐朝的影响向中国周边传播。例如当我们观察吐蕃帝国的灭亡，就会注意到全国性奴隶起义这样一个极为特殊的事件。这至少说明了三件，第一，吐蕃帝国是个过于早熟的古典形式的帝国，奴隶制仍然是最主要的剥削方式。第二，如此庞大统治范围内摧毁帝国的奴隶起义在世界上也是罕见的，说明吐蕃帝国在长期对外战争中过度汲取了社会资源。第

三，古典帝国晚期固然会出现叛乱，但是帝国本身很难被叛乱直接摧毁，原因在于已经封建化的地主阶级会借镇压叛乱的势头增强自己的力量，如东汉末年黄巾起义时的情况。而吐蕃全然没有遏制起义的燎原烈火的能力，说明其社会离封建化还很远，根本就没有能站出来应对局面的封建领主，乃至吐蕃中央政府在崩溃之后全境陷入无序的状态。正是基于这种观察，我们可以说日本在飞鸟奈良时期选择仿照唐朝进行全面改革虽然从日本本身的发展进程上看是怪异的，但是考虑到当时东亚地区所出现的历史现实，又不得不承认这种选择有一定的必然性。

接下来发生的事情堪称人类历史上真正的英雄传奇，无论日本在何种程度上没有办法去完全复制唐代的集权体制，但是在经过奈良时期之后，日本的官僚统治仍然因为学习中国显著强于一般的古典国家。当我在阅读有关内容时对于当时日本社会产生的一些思想及其反思感到非常惊讶，因为时至今日我依然能在中国感受到它们的存在。例如在平安时代前期，日本朝廷对于边界的态度与中华帝国别无二致，如果有蛮夷越过边境迁入帝国境内，那就一定是受到了天子之德的感化，朝廷从不吝惜民脂民膏予以优待；而一旦帝国的百姓试图越过边境前往“污秽的”未开化之地则被视为叛国，一旦捉住严惩不贷。事实上，当年真的有很多律令制下编户齐民的百姓因为难以忍受朝廷的残酷压迫而逃往虾夷控制区，这与中国北方边地的汉族老百姓逃出长城何其相似！飞鸟奈良时期的日本诗人山上忆良可谓知识分子良心，他本人为官并无大难，虽然速度不快但是一直平稳在官僚体制内晋升，并且与封疆大吏太宰帅大伴旅人私交甚笃。但是忆良却没有成为现有体制的维护者，其诗歌始终站在人民群众的立场上，无所保留地叙述了人民在律令制下的苦难。他不但生活的年代要早于中国的杜甫，而且在思想上进步得多，忆良从不避讳人民的苦难就来源于朝廷本身，而杜甫总是遮遮掩掩。就是在这样一种严酷的社会环境下，日本又没有经历过民族大迁徙这一历史事件，缺少来自外力的封建化动机。因此，日本武士仅仅从内部就终结了官僚统治，使日本在平安时代中期之后几个世纪中转化为一个与西欧类似的封建社会，其功业的成色自不待言。

日本的历史让我想到了曾经看过的一个有趣的故事，它发生在现在密克罗尼西亚联邦首都所在的波纳佩岛（Pohnpei），该岛可能位于南岛民族向太平洋扩张的路径上。波纳佩岛流传这样一个故事，在公元12世纪之前，最早的定居者就已经登上了波纳佩岛，不过当时还处于部落社会。在1100年前后，一群与本地人截然不同的征服者乘坐独木舟到达了该岛，并且带来了岛民前所未见的事物，也就是政府，建立了绍德雷尔王朝（Saudeleur）。这个新政权修建了宏伟的巨石建筑，现在的世界遗产南马都尔

（Man Madol）作为首都。当然，也必然带来压迫，该政权强迫人民向神灵进贡大量的食物作为贡品，令当地的阶级分化越来越明显。被统治的人民开始不断试图抵抗，例如暗杀国王和窃取贡品。在17世纪的某个时候，绍德雷尔王朝的统治终于完全无法维持，据说一个英雄征服了这个王国，集权式的国家统治被废除，几个大部落共同统治了这个岛屿。波纳佩岛非常小，这里发生的历史说起来也非常简单，不过却清楚地说明了当一套过于先进的社会制度被强行引入到无法支撑起这套体制的地区会发生什么。南岛人迁徙的整体方向是从西向东，当较晚的移民从亚洲大陆沿海出发时很可能已经习惯了早期国家形态，难以意识到当自己向东航行到太平洋的岛屿时，受到岛屿大小的限制，同时也因为技术的丧失，在新领地维持原有的社会形态并不可行。从本质上讲，日本虽然比波纳佩岛大得多得多，但是其历史遭遇也是如此。更何况隋唐帝国的复辟官僚制度跟先进没有半点关系，完全是人类社会这个“机体”长出的肿瘤。日本社会既没有让这个肿瘤肆意生长的条件，日本武士在后来也做出了坚决的斗争，因而日本列岛最终回归到了正常的历史发展进程上来。